

THE GRID WIRE

Vol 16 | Wednesday, June 10, 2026 | 6:00 PM ET cut, expanded full edition, updated through the June 10 close | All-sector coverage: AI infrastructure, oil and gas, midstream and LNG, solar, storage, geothermal, nuclear and uranium, utilities, compression, transmission, electrification

I. The Tape

Series	Level	Context
UST 30Y	~5.0%; yields flat post-CPI	Off the 5.20% May 19 cycle high (highest since 2007). Treasuries took the in-line print without a long-end break. ^{1,2,3}
May CPI (actual, 8:30 ET)	4.2% Y/Y; core 2.9%	Headline +0.5% M/M, highest Y/Y since April 2023. Core +0.2% M/M, BELOW the 0.3% estimate. Energy +3.9% M/M, >60% of the monthly increase. See §II. ³
Fed hike odds (CME)	>70% of one or more hikes in 2026	Repriced after the hot June 5 jobs report. First hiking-cycle pricing since the AI credit stack was built. ⁴
WTI (crude)	~\$90, +2% today	Jumped after Trump said Iran "will have to pay the price" and that strikes on plants and bridges are close. EIA: -7.23M bbl, seventh straight weekly draw. Off ~20% from 2026 peak. ^{5,6}
Waha (gas)	Summer strip -\$4.69; cash ~\$3.00	Latest published marks (May 22). Henry Hub below \$3.50 most of 2026 despite the war. Structurally negative. ^{7,40}
Uranium (U3O8 spot)	~\$86/lb	Held near \$86 through May on AI power demand; Cameco sees deficit by the 2030s. ⁴¹
Permian rig count	~240 (Enverus)	Up from the spring trough; 245 in May. Q1 permits 761 vs 514 in Q4. Crude-driven; gas rigs flat. ⁴²
Equities (June 10 close)	Dow -800+ pts (-1.65%); VIX +12%	Third consecutive down session: Iran headlines plus the 4-handle CPI. Tech, industrials, discretionary led decliners. Oracle reports Q4 FY26 after the bell. APLD -5.7% digesting its priced notes. ^{8,9}
ERCOT large-load queue	438 GW	More than five times record system peak. Batch Zero goes to the PUCT June 18. ¹⁰

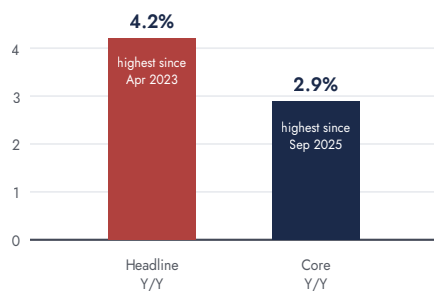
II. Lead: The First Hiking Cycle the AI Credit Stack Has Ever Seen

The print is in, and it is a split screen. Headline CPI rose 0.5% in May, putting the annual rate at 4.2%, the fastest since April 2023 and exactly in line with consensus. Core rose 0.2% on the month, below the 0.3% estimate, with the annual core rate at 2.9%, the highest since September 2025 but also in line. Energy jumped 3.9% in the month, is up 23.5% over twelve months, and accounted for more than 60% of the monthly all-items increase. Core

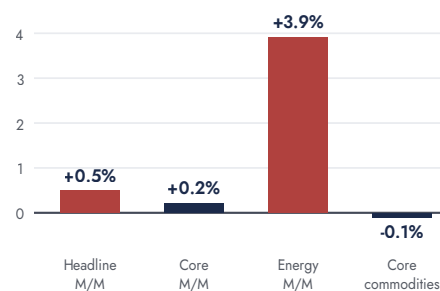
commodities fell 0.1%, indicating muted tariff pass-through.^{3,11} The NSA index printed 335.123. Treasuries took it flat; equity futures pared losses on the release before the Iran tape took over (see §I, §XVI).

The honest read cuts both ways. The headline leg of the thesis is confirmed: the Iran-war energy shock is now compounding in the official data, two consecutive hot headline months, and the FOMC meets June 17 staring at a 4-handle. The hiking leg is tested but intact: the soft 0.2% monthly core is the strongest single data point the doves have received since the war began, and the market read it as relief that the energy shock has not yet spilled into broad prices. CME odds of a 2026 hike, north of 70% after Friday's jobs report, are the number to watch into the Fed meeting; a hold next week with hawkish language remains the base case.⁴ The structural exposure is unchanged either way: every delayed-draw term loan in the AI complex floats over SOFR, struck in a market that assumed the next move was down. The long end already made a 2007 high in May on the inflation leg alone. The hiking leg is optionality against the same positions, not the requirement.

May CPI, actual (Y/Y)



May CPI, actual (M/M)



Energy drove over 60% of the monthly increase; core commodities fell

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The 2023-2026 cost-of-capital compression was underwritten on a falling-rate assumption that is now dead on both ends: the long end made a 2007 high in May and the short end is pricing hikes. Floating-rate AI infrastructure debt is structurally short the Fed. The instruments most exposed are precisely the ones celebrated as the asset class's maturation.

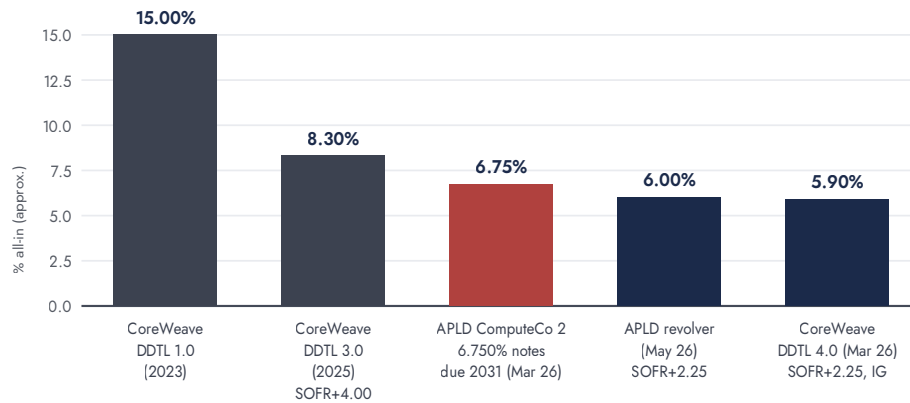
Falsification (status after the print): the stated condition was core at or below 2.7% with hike odds below 40%. Core printed 2.9%: not triggered, thesis stands. The remaining test is hike odds through the June 17 FOMC; below 40% kills the hiking leg, and the long-end inflation leg survives independently. The 0.2% monthly core is the named risk to the hiking leg and is acknowledged as such.

III. Deals, Financings, and Capital Flows: The Term Sheets, All Sectors

Date	Transaction	Terms
Jun 9 (priced)	Applied Digital \$1.59B notes	Priced: 7.000% senior secured notes due 2031, at par. APLD ComputeCo 3 LLC, 144A/Reg S, closing ~June 16. Proceeds fund 150 MW of critical IT load at ELN-04 (Polaris Forge 1, Ellendale, ND), repay a Goldman Sachs bridge loan, and fund debt service reserves; first-priority liens on substantially all ELN-04 assets and equity, plus an APLD completion guarantee. Coupon ladder across the franchise: 9.250% (Nov 2025), 6.750% at 98 (Mar), 7.000% at par (Jun). APLD equity -5.7% on the day digesting the leverage. ¹²

Jun 8 (closed May 29)	Applied Digital revolver	\$350M committed + \$200M accordion, arranged by Goldman Sachs. SOFR+225 bps or ABR+125. Matures May 29, 2029. Secured by certain non-data-center project assets. ¹³
Jun 8	Applied Digital 210 MW lease	Delta Forge 2, fifth campus in the AI Factory franchise model. Tenant identity, rent, and tenor n/d. ¹⁴
Jun 5	Applied Digital / CoreWeave MOU	Lease for Building 3, Polaris Forge 1, to be assigned to a CoreWeave subsidiary if that subsidiary achieves an investment grade credit rating. See §IV. ¹³
Jun 1	Anthropic confidential IPO filing	Filed June 1, ahead of OpenAI. \$125B total equity raised to date. Follows the May 28 \$65B Series H at \$965B post (Altimeter, Dragoneer, Greenoaks, Sequoia co-leads; includes \$15B previously committed, of which \$5B Amazon). ^{15,16}
Jun 1	Cameco / Orano: Cigar Lake	Agreement to acquire TEPCO Resources' 5% participating interest in the Cigar Lake JV, lifting Cameco's stake in the mine. Price n/d. ⁴³
May-Jun	OpenAI confidential IPO filing	Filed confidentially. Earlier-2026 private round reported at \$110B/\$840B post by one outlet and \$122B/\$852B by another; definitive terms n/d. ~\$180B raised privately to date. ^{15,17}
May (Reuters)	NextEra / Dominion merger talks	Reported exploration of a potential merger, extending the utility M&A wave. Terms, structure, and status n/d. See §IX. ⁴⁴
Pending	SpaceX IPO	Targeting ~\$75B raise; valuation reports range \$1.75T to \$2T. Largest IPO in history if completed. ^{15,17}
Apr 30	Meta \$25B IG bonds	Second jumbo in six months after the record \$30B October print (largest non-M&A IG deal ever). 2026 capex guide raised to \$125-145B. ^{18,19}
Apr	Fervo Energy IPO filing	Filed to fund a 3.6 GW enhanced-geothermal pipeline. Follows \$421M non-recourse project financing (March) and a \$462M round backed by Google and CalSTRS (February). Cape Station 500 MW fully contracted. ⁴⁵
Mar 17	Tesla / LG Energy Solution	\$4.3B LFP cell supply agreement; new Lansing, MI plant; contract runs Aug 1, 2027 to Jul 31, 2030 with a seven-year extension option, feeding Megapack 3 assembly in Houston (50 GWh/yr target from late 2026). Tesla's Korean storage-cell commitments now exceed \$6.4B. ⁴⁶
Mar 13	Venture Global CP2 Phase 2 FID	First US LNG export plant sanctioned in 2026. \$8.6B project financing (BoFA, Barclays, DB, GS, JPM, Mizuho, Natixis, RBC, StanChart, Wells et al.; BBVA and MUFG lead arrangers), total CP2 financing \$20.7B. ⁴⁷
Feb 26	Archrock note redemption	Redeemed all \$800M 6.25% senior notes due 2028 at par on April 1. Compression credit de-levering while AI credit levers up. ⁴⁸
Stock (2026)	Hyperscaler debt complex	Combined big-four 2026 capex ~\$700B+, +77% Y/Y. Morgan Stanley: \$250-300B hyperscaler issuance in 2026. JPMorgan: \$30-40B/yr data-center securitization. Alphabet issued a 100-year bond in February (\$31.5B raised). ^{17,20}
May (S&P data)	PE data-center record	US private-equity data-center investment \$45.7B in 2025, 72% of the \$63.35B total, led by the \$40B Aligned acquisition (MGX, Global Infrastructure, Microsoft). ²¹

The cost-of-capital tape, June 2026: IG vs HY AI infrastructure debt (stated/approx fixed-equivalent)



DDTL 1.0/3.0/4.0 from CoreWeave 8-Ks and financing presentations; APLD ComputeCo 2 coupon from APLD FY26 8-K (6.750% due 2031, issued at 98). Floating instruments shown at indicative fixed-equivalents; they reprice upward with any hike.

IV. Applied Digital Forensics: The Rating Is Now a Transferable Asset

Four APLD events in five days form one structure, and the June 5 CoreWeave MOU is the part the market read past. The assignment of the Building 3 lease is conditioned not on payment, not on completion, but on a CoreWeave subsidiary achieving an investment grade rating.¹³ Read against the financing stack it sits inside (Macquarie preferred at 12.75% PIK above, 6.750% secured notes at 98 beside, a SOFR+225 revolver on non-project collateral), the mechanic is explicit: tenant credit quality is being engineered at the subsidiary level so the landlord's project debt can re-rate. CoreWeave already terminated one APLD-adjacent arrangement in March when underlying tenant credit failed; this MOU is the corrected architecture.

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The DDTL 4.0 lesson has propagated: the rating, not the asset, is the negotiated commodity in AI infrastructure credit. Counterparties now structure SPVs to receive a rating the way they once structured them to receive collateral. Efficient while ratings hold, pro-cyclical when they do not, because every instrument keyed to the same rating event re-prices together. The recovery floor under all of it remains the land, power, and water at the project site, which carry no rating and need none.

Falsification (status): half the test resolved today. ELN-04 priced at 7.000% at par, inside the stated 7.5% threshold: the market is still paying for the structure, not charging for the asset. The 25 bps of widening versus March's 6.750% issue matches the rate backdrop, not a credit re-rating. The remaining test is the Building 3 assignment closing without the subsidiary's IG rating. Note the same-day equity read: APLD stock fell 5.7% on the pricing. Credit pays for the structure; equity pays for the leverage. That divergence is \$V's CoreWeave pattern, one tier down the stack.

V. CoreWeave: The Equity Layer Is Selling What the Credit Layer Is Buying

Bloomberg, June 9: CoreWeave executives have sold more than \$2.3B of stock since the March 2025 IPO, the bulk by co-founders Intrator, McBee, and Venturo; Intrator sold 307,692 shares for \$37.7M on June 2 alone; Magnetar holds 9.7%.^{9,22} The same fourteen months produced the DDTL ladder ending in the \$8.5B A3/A(low) facility at SOFR+2.25%. Q1 prints were

strong on their own terms: revenue \$2.1B (+112%), backlog \$99.4B, more than 1 GW of active power; GAAP net loss widened to \$740M.²³ Russell 3000 inclusion lands June 26, importing index-mandated buyers.²⁴

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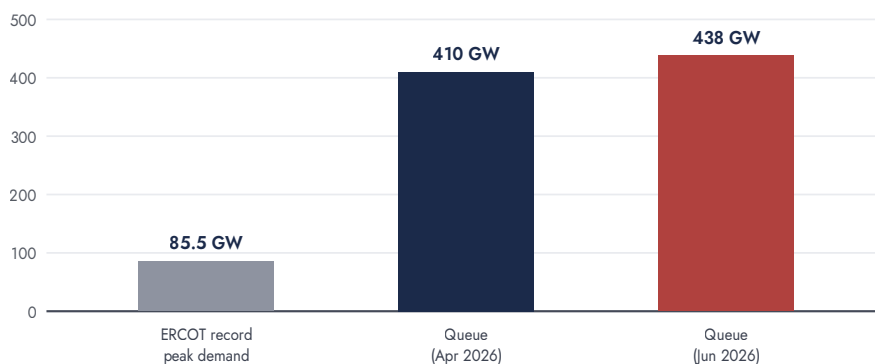
Lenders re-rated the company to investment grade in the same window its founders liquidated \$2.3B of equity. Both sides can be right simultaneously only if the durable value sits below the equity claim: in the contracts, the sites, and the power, which is where the collateral agent's lien actually attaches. June 26 then hands the exit liquidity to index funds that buy by mandate, the same rating-not-fundamentals buyer base as the credit.

Falsification: sustained founder buying, or a clean DSCR test at first measurement in 2027 alongside spread compression through SOFR+200.

VI. Power and Grid: Batch Zero Is SB6's Enforcement Mechanism

The ERCOT board approved the Batch Zero framework June 1-2; it goes to the PUCT for final approval on **June 18**.^{10,25} The queue it will sort now stands at 438 GW against a record system peak of roughly 85 GW, with ~200 data centers seeking connection in 2026 alone.¹⁰ Batch Zero replaces serial study with batch study and, critically, allocates available transmission capacity to studied and committed large loads. Combined with the Docket 58481 regime (\$50,000/MW non-refundable fee, demonstrated site control, security forfeiture on withdrawal), the batch is a forced sort: phantom load dies in the study, controlled land survives it. Cipher's 1,000 MW Colchis project, with an executed AEP direct-connect agreement, states it expects inclusion in Batch Zero; that is what the survivor profile looks like.²⁶

ERCOT large-load interconnection queue vs. record system peak (GW)



Turbines: the 2029-2030 shelf is nearly gone

GE Vernova Q1 (April 22): 21 GW of new gas equipment contracts signed in the quarter; backlog 40 to 44 GW; slot reservations 43 to 56 GW; combined 83 to 100 GW, guided to at least 110 GW by year-end. New-order pricing is tracking 10-20 points above Q4 2025 on a \$/kW basis; Wood Mackenzie projects \$600/kW by end-2027, near triple 2019. The company entered Q1 with ~10 GW of available 2029 production capacity; after one quarter of customers reaching into 2030, approximately 10 GW remains across 2029 and 2030 combined.^{27,28}

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Two allocation systems are closing in the same month: ERCOT is converting queue position into allocated transmission capacity, and the turbine market has effectively converted the 2029-2030 delivery window into held inventory. Both are pure seniority systems. Capital cannot jump either line; only pre-held position can. Every dollar of the \$700B hyperscaler capex wave that arrives after these windows close bids for the same fixed physical set.

Falsification: PUCT rejects or materially waters down Batch Zero June 18, or GEV's Q2 print shows 2029-2030 slot availability expanding rather than contracting.

VII. Electrification: The Bottleneck Has Moved Inside the Fence Line

Company	State of play
Eaton (ETN)	Q1 2026: revenue \$7.45B (+17%), data-center orders +240% Y/Y, data-center revenue +50%, backlog \$22.8B. Earnings grew only +2% against +17% revenue: capacity-expansion cost is eating margin. CEO Sternadt on Q4: backlog "equates to eleven years of what was built in 2025." Bought Boyd Thermal (\$9.5B, liquid cooling, ~\$1.7B 2026 revenue) and Fibrebond (\$1.45B). ^{49,50}
Vertiv (VRT)	Backlog \$15.0B, +109% Y/Y; Q4 2025 book-to-bill ~2.9x; TTM organic orders +81%. Q1 2026 revenue \$2.65B (+30%), adjusted EPS +83%, adjusted operating margin 20.8% (+430 bps). The only large vendor covering both power and cooling. ^{51,52}
GE Vernova (Electrification)	\$7.1B segment orders in Q1, ~2.5x book-to-bill; \$2.4B of data-center equipment orders in one quarter, more than all of 2025. ²⁷
Transformer capacity	Hitachi Energy: \$1B+ North American investment including what is planned as the largest US large-power-transformer plant (Virginia, by 2028). Siemens Energy: \$1B+ including a Charlotte, NC plant targeting 2027 production. ⁵³
The constraint	Bloomberg (April 1): more than half of US data centers planned for 2026 are now expected to be delayed or canceled for lack of transformers, switchgear, and electrical gear, not money or land; only ~one-third of the 12-16 GW planned for this year is actually under construction; delivery runs 3-5 years. ⁵⁴

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Eaton's own numbers are the tell: revenue +17%, earnings +2%. When the bottleneck vendor cannot convert record orders into record earnings because it is spending the margin on capacity, the scarcity rent is not yet being captured by the equipment maker; it is being captured by whoever already holds energized capacity. That is why already-built data centers and already-interconnected sites are re-rating faster than the equipment complex, and it is the same logic as the turbine slots: the queue is the asset. The \$XII safe-harbor procurement sprint lands on this exact supply chain for the next 24 days.

Falsification: Eaton or Vertiv Q2 backlogs flat-to-down sequentially, or transformer lead times publicly shortening below 24 months.

VIII. Transmission: Texas Decides Its First 765 kV Line This Month

The PUCT's decision on Oncor's first 765 kV line is expected in **June 2026**; Oncor anticipates energization by December 2028 if approved.⁵⁵ The Permian Basin Reliability Plan's three approved 765 kV import paths (April 2025) run directly through the project geography: Howard to Solstice (AEP Texas / CPS Energy, ~370 miles, Solstice substation near Fort Stockton to San Antonio; CCN amendment filed March 2026), Bell East to Big Hill to Sand Lake (LCRA/Oncor), and

Dinosaur to Longshore to Drill Hole, with the Drill Hole-Sand Lake-Solstice western link identified in Culberson, Ward, Reeves, and Pecos counties.^{56,57,58} Oncor and LCRA filed March 26 for up to 244 miles of additional 765 kV (Schleicher to Bell County) at \$1.6-1.9B plus ~\$400M of station work, route selection expected September, energization 2030, 50/50 ownership.⁵⁹

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Texas's first extra-high-voltage network is being built into the Permian, not out of it. The state is spending multi-billion-dollar, rate-based capital to make Pecos, Reeves, and Ward counties the best-interconnected rural load pocket in ERCOT, with bidirectional flow. Every approved mile raises the value of land adjacent to Solstice, Sand Lake, and Drill Hole before a single data center signs. The PUCT order this month is the first conversion of that plan into steel-in-the-ground commitment.

Falsification: the PUCT denies or materially delays the first 765 kV CCN this month, or the Permian import paths are re-scoped below 765 kV.

IX. Utilities and IPPs: Consolidation Reaches the Top of the Sector

Name	State of play
NextEra / Dominion	Reuters: exploring a potential merger. Terms n/d. A combination would unite the largest US renewables developer with the utility serving Loudoun County, the densest data-center load pocket on earth. The market read it as the M&A wave reaching the supermajors of power. ⁴⁴
Vistra (VST)	Q1: GAAP net income \$1,029M (incl. \$723M unrealized hedge gain); reaffirmed 2026 adjusted EBITDA guide \$6.8-7.6B. Upgraded to investment grade at a second major agency (Fitch BBB-, March). Priced \$500M senior notes due 2028. Meta nuclear agreements up to 6.6 GW; Comanche Peak 20-year PPA with an unnamed hyperscaler; Cogentrix added 5.5 GW of gas. ^{60,61,62}
Constellation (CEG)	Crane restart: FERC waiver decision expected June or July on transferring Eddystone capacity interconnection rights; PJM's market monitor opposes. Microsoft 20-year PPA estimated at \$100-102/MWh, roughly double the merchant/PTC floor. PJM upgrades for full deliverability have slipped toward 2030-2031: the single most important near-term catalyst for the name. ⁶³
Talen / Amazon	The 17-year Susquehanna PPA (~\$68.90/MWh implied benchmark, ~\$18B revenue) remains the floor price for existing-fleet nuclear offtake; every subsequent deal has printed above it. ⁶⁴

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The nuclear PPA tape now runs \$68.90 (Talen/AWS, 2024 vintage) to \$100-102/MWh (Constellation/Microsoft). That 45%+ escalation in two years is the clearest printed price series for firm, carbon-free capacity scarcity, and it is the same seniority logic again: the uncontracted existing fleet shrinks with every deal, and the marginal buyer pays the new high. NextEra-Dominion, if real, is a bid for load-pocket position, not generation; Loudoun interconnection is the scarce asset Dominion holds.

Falsification: a new gigawatt-scale nuclear PPA printing below ~\$70/MWh, or FERC denying the Crane waiver and Microsoft renegotiating rather than holding price.

X. Nuclear Fuel and SMRs: The Fuel Cycle Tightens Quietly

Uranium held near \$86/lb through May on AI power demand.⁴¹ Cameco: 2026 production guidance reaffirmed at 19.5-21.5 Mlb U3O8 (share) with ~28 Mlb/yr of delivery commitments 2026-2030; Key Lake mill and McArthur River mine returned to

full production May 27 after northern Saskatchewan flooding; on June 1 Cameco and Orano agreed to acquire TEPCO's 5% of the Cigar Lake JV; the 49% Westinghouse stake contributed C\$122M of adjusted EBITDA share plus a US\$49M cash distribution in Q1. Cameco's own framing: 72 reactors under construction globally, supply deficit in the 2030s.^{41,43,65} SMRs remain pre-revenue: NuScale and Oklo sold off hard in the June 5 risk break (NuScale -20% over the stretch; Goldman cut its target to \$9); neither has a grid-connected reactor.^{66,67}

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The TEPCO buyout is small and telling: the incumbent producer is consolidating ownership of existing, licensed, producing uranium assets at the same time the equity market chases pre-revenue SMR paper. Cameco is doing in fuel what this report argues for in land and water: buying the adjudicated, producing physical position while the speculative claim layer absorbs the volatility. Existing pounds, like existing megawatts and existing acre-feet, cannot be financed into existence on the demand curve's timeline.

Falsification: U3O8 closing below \$70/lb for a month, or an SMR developer signing a binding, priced offtake with delivery before 2030.

XI. Solar, Storage, Geothermal: The OBBBA Sort Is Re-Routing Capital

Segment	State of play
Solar: First Solar (FSLR)	Q1: net sales \$1.04B (+24%), diluted EPS \$3.22 (+65%), contracted backlog 47.9 GW, gross cash \$2.4B; guidance reaffirmed. TOPCon patent litigation against JinkoSolar stayed pending the USITC determination. As the only US-headquartered top-tier module maker, FSLR is the structural beneficiary of both the FEOC content rules and the §XII safe-harbor procurement sprint. ⁶⁸
Battery storage	Tesla/LG \$4.3B domestic LFP deal (terms in §III) de-risks Megapack 3's 50 GWh/yr Houston ramp from tariff exposure. EIA: US installed storage 51.2 GW by April 2026, ~88.4 GW by December 2027, a near-double in two years. Fluence: Smartstack platform plus a 1 GWh domestically manufactured deployment with Cordelio. Today: EDP Renewables and SRP completed Arizona's largest battery storage project. ^{46,69}
Geothermal	Fervo: Cape Station first 100 MW targeted on the grid in 2026, 500 MW by 2028, fully contracted (Google 115 MW clean-transition tariff; Shell Energy 31 MW, 15-year); \$421M non-recourse project financing in March; IPO filed April against a 3.6 GW pipeline. Sage Geosystems: \$97M January round co-led by incumbent Ormat; 150 MW Meta agreement in Texas, first phase 2027. Meta added 150 MW with XGS in New Mexico. ^{45,70}

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The OBBBA did not kill the credit complex; it sorted it. Wind and solar face the July 4 cliff; storage, geothermal, and nuclear keep full credit value into the 2030s. Capital is responding exactly as the statute directs: storage capacity doubling in two years, geothermal graduating to IPO and non-recourse project finance, and solar compressing into a 24-day procurement sprint plus a flight to FEOC-clean domestic manufacturers. The losers are not technologies; they are post-deadline wind and solar developers without safe-harbored equipment, whose pipelines now transfer value to whoever holds grandfathered position. Seniority again.

Falsification: Congress or Treasury extends the wind/solar deadline, or Cape Station misses 2026 first power, which would re-price geothermal technology risk across the complex.

XII. Policy: A Court Just Restored the 5% Safe Harbor With 24 Days Left on the Clock

On June 6 the US District Court for DC, in *Oregon Environmental Council v. IRS* (No. 25-4400, CKK), vacated IRS Notice 2025-42 in full as arbitrary and capricious and remanded to the agency.^{29,30} The notice had eliminated the 5% safe harbor and made the physical-work test the only path for wind and large solar to establish beginning of construction ahead of the OBBBA's July 4, 2026 deadline. Projects that begin construction by July 4 keep the four-year continuity runway (in service by end-2030); projects that miss it must be in service by December 31, 2027.^{30,31} The decision stands unless stayed or reversed; the IRS may seek emergency relief.

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With 24 days to the statutory cliff, the vacatur converts a physical-work race into a procurement race: 5% safe harbor means qualifying spend, and qualifying spend means panels, trackers, transformers, and inverters bought before July 4. This is a compressed, deadline-driven equipment pull-forward landing on the \$VII supply chain, where more than half of 2026's data centers are already delayed on electrical gear. The cliff was supposed to slow the buildout. For the next 24 days it accelerates demand on the exact components the AI buildout is short.

Falsification: an emergency stay or appellate reversal before July 4.

XIII. Oil and Gas Upstream, Services, and Compression: Discipline Broke on the Crude Side Only

Crude-directed activity

Diamondback formally retired its "stoplight" framework on May 4 and declared green: Q1 averaged 521,000 b/d of oil, above the top of guidance; full-year raised to 520,000+ b/d; 2-3 rigs and five frac crews added immediately; capex up from \$3.75B to \$3.9B. It is the first major Permian operator to openly break from the post-2022 capital-discipline playbook, with Continental and ConocoPhillips signaling similar moves.⁷¹ Permian rigs hit 245 in May (Enverus), ~240 this week; independents pulled 761 new permits in Q1 vs 514 in Q4; Diamondback holds 73 unfracked DUCs, the most among independents (Rystad). EnergyWire's June 5 assessment: the ramp adds only ~250,000 b/d, too little to move the global price.⁴²

Gas-directed activity (separate)

Gas-focused producers are not expanding: Henry Hub has held below \$3.50 for most of 2026 despite the war, EQT has curtailed output on weak spot prices, and Diamondback says it is "consciously moving away from Waha" pricing exposure toward demand centers, export points, and planned data centers. EIA raised its 2026 dry gas production forecast to 110.61 Bcf/d.^{40,72}

Compression

Archrock Q1: contract operations revenue \$330.9M (+10%); redeemed the entire \$800M of 6.25% notes due 2028 at par April 1; 2026 growth capex \$250-275M concentrated in large-horsepower and electric-motor-drive units; sold 325,000 HP for \$192M and redeployed into new builds. USA Compression sits inside the Energy Transfer complex and is excluded from ET's growth capex figure.^{48,73}

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Read the two halves together and the basin's machine is now explicit: war-priced crude pulls rigs back, rigs produce associated gas regardless of Waha, and the gas side of every one of those wells is priced below zero at the hub. Diamondback's green light is therefore a gas supply announcement wearing an oil headline, and it extends the structurally negative Waha regime that underwrites every behind-the-meter Permian power project. Meanwhile the compression sector, the one OFS niche levered to moving that gas, is de-levering at par while AI infrastructure levers up at SOFR+225: the physical-services layer is the only part of the energy complex behaving as if rates matter.

Falsification: Diamondback re-imposes the stoplight framework, or Waha cash sustains above -\$1.00 through the summer without new in-basin demand announcements.

XIV. Midstream and LNG: Twenty-Year Paper, Mid-Teens Returns

Name	State of play
Energy Transfer (ET)	2026 growth capex \$5.0-5.5B, mostly gas network, targeted mid-teens returns at sub-6.0x EBITDA build multiples. Mustang Draw I (275 MMcf/d Permian processing) reaches full service this month. Springerville Lateral approved: 120 miles, 625 MMcf/d, ~\$600M, 20-year contracts, replacing two coal plants, ISD Q4 2029. Nederland ethane export contracts extended to 2041. FGT Phase IX (~525 MMcf/d) open season complete on 15-25 year anchor agreements. ^{74,75} Separately today, Sempra brought a key Gulf Coast gas pipeline online for Port Arthur LNG. ⁷⁶
Venture Global (VG)	CP2 Phase 2 FID March 13 with \$8.6B project financing; total CP2 financing \$20.7B; first US export plant sanctioned in 2026. Phase 1 (14.4 Mt/y design, upscalable to 20) targets first LNG 2027. ^{47,76}
Kinder Morgan (KMI)	\$500M KinderHawk expansion to 2 Bcf/d in the Haynesville on life-of-lease dedications, full service late 2026. Internal projection: +28 Bcf/d US gas demand by 2030 from LNG, power, and Mexico. Trident (2.8 Bcf/d, Katy to Gulf Coast) anchored by Golden Pass. ⁷⁷

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ET is printing 15-to-25-year shipper contracts and 20-year power-conversion laterals at sub-6x build multiples while AI data-center landlords lease at n/d tenors to tenants whose credit is being engineered SPV-by-SPV (§IV). The midstream sector is quietly writing the longest, hardest paper in the entire energy-AI complex, against physical molecules, at returns the AI credit stack cannot match risk-adjusted. The market pays 30x for the claim layer and single-digit multiples for the layer with the 2041 contracts.

Falsification: ET guiding build multiples above 7x or a major LNG offtaker defaulting on a take-or-pay, which would reprice the contract layer's assumed durability.

XV. Natural Gas: Waha Is Still the Cheapest Molecule in North America

Latest published marks: June prompt fixed price -\$5.69/MMBtu and basis -\$8.25 as of May 1; Summer 2026 strip -\$4.69 and cash near -\$3.00 as of May 22, with Henry Hub June at \$2.78.⁷ Permian production averaged a record 27.6 Bcf/d in 2025 and the EIA projects continued growth with rising gas-to-oil ratios, now reinforced by the \$XIII crude-side rig adds.³² Egress schedule: Gulf Coast Express expansion (+570 MMcf/d) in service window 2Q; Energy Transfer's Hugh Brinson (~\$2.7B) may flow some gas early Q3, with phase 1 (1.5 Bcf/d) in Q4 2026 and phase 2 (0.7 Bcf/d) in Q1 2027; Blackcomb follows Q4.^{7,32} AEGIS's own framing: relief will be short-lived because supply fills new capacity quickly.

Permian gas: Waha vs Henry Hub (\$/MMBtu, AEGIS/NGI latest published)



Demand-side confirmation keeps arriving: CloudBurst's Energy Transfer supply agreement (up to 450,000 MMBtu/d via Oasis, ~1.2 GW behind-the-meter, operations from Q3 2026), New Era Helium / Sharon AI's 250 MW off-grid Permian JV, and Fermi's contracted 300,000 MMBtu/d of Permian supply for Matador, project delays notwithstanding.^{33,34,35} The structurally negative hub and the behind-the-meter buildout are the same fact viewed from opposite sides of the meter.

XVI. Crude: De-escalation Tape, Closed Strait

Kept strictly separate from the gas analysis above. WTI eased to ~\$91 from \$95 Monday after Iran stated it had ended military operations against Israel following a weekend ceasefire breach; Brent ~\$94.63.^{5,6} The Strait of Hormuz remains effectively closed under a dual US-Iran blockade. OPEC+ approved another +188,000 b/d for July quotas. China's May crude imports fell to ~7.8 mb/d, the lowest in more than eight years and ~4 mb/d below the 2025 average, which together with record US exports and SPR releases is capping the price impact.⁵ Fitch expects the strait could reopen around end-July and models Brent averaging \$87 for full-year 2026, with oversupply risk into Q4 as production recovers, now compounded by the \$XIII shale ramp.⁶ Crude is off ~20% from 2026 peaks.³⁶ The crude tape is normalizing; the inflation it already injected into the CPI base is not, which is the asymmetry \$II trades on.

XVII. West Texas Focal Points: June 18 Is the Most Important Date on the Texas Calendar

Item	Status
PUCT Batch Zero vote	June 18. Final approval of the framework allocating ERCOT transmission capacity by batch to committed, site-controlled loads. ²⁵
Reeves County GCD	Historical Use Permit deadline September 1, 2026 : 83 days out. Next board meeting is June 18 , the same day as the PUCT vote. HUP filings convert documented historical beneficial use into production rights above the 6 ac-ft/contiguous-acre cap; unfiled use lapses to the cap. Formation date of the first tradeable senior groundwater market in the US. ³⁷
765 kV into the basin	PUCT decision on Oncor's first 765 kV line expected this month; Howard-Solstice, Big Hill-Sand Lake, and Drill Hole-Sand Lake-Solstice paths run through Pecos, Reeves, Ward, and Culberson counties (§VIII). ^{55,58}

Chevron / Microsoft / Engine No. 1	Exclusivity negotiations on the Permian behind-the-meter project (2.5 GW initial, 5 GW potential) reported in April remain the standing template for gas-plus-compute in the basin. Definitive terms n/d. ³⁸
Pacifico GW Ranch	Holds the largest air permit issued in the country (February, TCEQ); full buildout would more than double Texas gas-fired capacity if completed as permitted. ³⁹
OBBBA cliff	July 4: 24 days. Safe-harbor procurement rush per §XII now in effect statewide.

ANGLE

On one day, June 18, Texas finalizes the rule converting grid queue position into allocated transmission property, and the Reeves County district holds its last scheduled board meeting before the deadline that converts historical pumping into senior water property. The same month, the PUCT decides the first 765 kV line of a network whose western terminus is the Solstice substation outside Fort Stockton. Three administrative acts, one direction: pre-held physical position in Pecos and Reeves counties is being converted into exclusive, transferable, rate-base-backed rights. Capital that shows up June 19 buys from whoever filed by June 18.

Falsification: the PUCT materially delays or rejects Batch Zero or the 765 kV CCN, or the Reeves GCD extends the HUP deadline past September 1, each of which defers (not destroys) the rights-formation event.

XVIII. Conclusions, Angled

1. The AI credit stack faces its first hiking cycle. Every SOFR-plus instrument was modeled in a cutting regime. This morning's CPI is the catalyst, not the cause.
2. The rating has become a transferable, negotiated asset (APLD/CoreWeave MOU). Peak financialization of the claim layer; it concentrates rather than distributes risk.
3. Founders sold \$2.3B of the equity the credit market re-rated to A3. The capital structure is telling you where the value migrated: down, toward the contracts and the sites.
4. Four seniority systems closed or are closing at once: ERCOT transmission (Batch Zero), turbine slots (GEV 2029-2030), electrical equipment (Eaton's eleven-year backlog), and nuclear offtake (the \$68.90-to-\$102/MWh PPA tape). In each, money no longer buys position; only prior position does.
5. The June 6 vacatur turns the OBBBA cliff into a 24-day equipment procurement sprint landing on a supply chain that has already delayed half of 2026's data centers. The OBBBA itself is a sort, not a kill: storage, geothermal, and nuclear keep full credit into the 2030s, and capital is migrating accordingly.
6. Diamondback's green light is a gas-supply announcement wearing an oil headline: crude-priced rigs extend the negative-Waha regime that underwrites every behind-the-meter Permian power project.
7. Midstream is writing the longest, hardest paper in the complex: 2041 ethane contracts and 20-year laterals at sub-6x build multiples, while the AI claim layer leases at n/d tenors to engineered-credit SPVs. The valuation gap between those two layers is the standing mispricing.
8. June 18: transmission rights and senior water rights crystallize into property on the same Texas calendar day, with the first 765 kV order due the same month, terminating at Solstice. Pre-held physical position in Pecos and Reeves is the only asset all three processes reward.

XIX. Footnotes and Sources

1. FRED DGS30, updated June 9, 2026 (5.03% for June 8); CNBC US30Y quote page, June 9 session range 5.005-5.028%.
2. CNN Business, May 19, 2026: 30Y at 5.2%, highest since 2007, on Iran-war inflation.
3. BLS CPI news release, May 2026 results, June 10, 8:30 ET: headline +0.5% M/M SA, +4.2% Y/Y, NSA index 335.123; CNBC, June 10: core +0.2% M/M (below 0.3% est), +2.9% Y/Y; energy +3.9% M/M, +23.5% Y/Y; core commodities -0.1%; yields flat and futures off lows post-release; FOMC June 17 expected hold. CryptoBriefing tally: energy >60% of the monthly all-items increase. Next CPI release July 14.
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7. AEGIS Hedging Waha Basis Brief: May 1 prompt fixed -\$5.69, basis -\$8.25, HH June \$2.78; May 22 Summer 2026 strip -\$4.69, cash ~-\$3.00; Hugh Brinson early-Q3 partial flow; GCX +570 MMcf/d 2Q.
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